plan Ratan had outlined for TISCO. Commenting on this aspect, Mukherjee says that the pre-eminence given to technology was ‘100 per cent on account of the initiative of Ratan Tata’. It was most critical for TISCO’s survival. Muthuraman remarked that adoption of newest technologies midwifed the ailing company’s ‘rebirth’. ‘[We] earned our right to live’ and ‘came out of the grave’ by embarking on an ambitious plan by adopting the most modern technologies in steel-making, he says.

Ratan’s penchant for technology, a critical moulder of his vision, is something he shared with the founder of the Tata Group. Jamsetji, for instance, used ‘ring spindles’ considered too advanced even for Lancashire, in the Empress Mills. Ratan has ‘an appreciation for new technology, which has been synonymous with the enterprise since the days of founder Jamshedji Tata’, wrote *Asiaweek*. JRD was fully aware of this and said of Ratan: ‘He has an understanding of modern science and technology. None of my other colleagues have it except Darbari Seth. Ratan has a modern mind.’

The steps that Ratan took to strengthen TIL also did not go unnoticed. He had persuaded the board to support his initiatives for high-tech industries. Some viewed it as evidence of his ability to succeed JRD. Writing in 1988, a leading magazine said: ‘Ratan Tata’s appointment a few years ago as chairman of Tata Industries, a shell holding company which he converted into a promoter of high technology companies, had pitchforked him into the limelight as JRD’s anointed heir.’

But perhaps the single most important factor that favoured Ratan’s appointment was his unflinching commitment to ethics and the sacrosanct values that underpin and permeate the entire philosophical foundation of Tata Group.

Simone Tata was quoted as saying: ‘The Tatas are a unique group, dominated not by family members but by the family name and philosophy —a corporate culture marked by a pioneering spirit, a reputation for integrity, and for serving employees, shareholders and the public well.’

Nusserwanji Tata, Jamsetji’s father, had established this standard. The partners of his firm, Nusserwanji and Kaliandas, ‘so completely trusted Nusserwanji Tata that they deemed no form of agreement to be necessary, and always received their due share of the profits’. Jamsetji was equally committed to these values. As a devout Parsi and a novitiate, he laid extraordinary emphasis on following the overarching edicts of ethical and